

Any in-depth statistical analysis of Grad Café data will be limited by selection bias and the self-reported nature of the dataset. For one, applicants with particularly positive or disappointing outcomes are much more likely to post, skewing the results. Also, certain programs and universities may be disproportionately represented, while other groups may be largely or entirely absent (I encountered this when pulling data on my alma mater, West Virginia University). Furthermore, applicants may report information incorrectly or inconsistently, which can affect calculations. Mathematically derived results, thus, should not automatically be interpreted as representative of the grad applicant population.

This can especially be seen in the GRE relevant fields. For example, many applicants likely put their total GRE score in the GRE General field rather than their quantitative score, which is why the average for that field significantly exceeds the number of points that can actually be scored. A similar story can be seen with the GRE Verbal and Analytical Writing fields. It's also worth noting that if applicants from certain universities, programs, or geographic backgrounds are more likely to use Grad Café, their characteristics may have a greater influence on the results than those of less represented groups. As such, the analysis can identify patterns within the collected Grad Café records, but it cannot independently establish that those patterns apply to the general population of grad applicants.